While all this was going on, Covid was already rearing its head. There had been increasing reports in the media of cases surfacing all across the globe. My younger daughter, Amala, had come to India and was due to return to Singapore in the first week of February 2020. The evening before her departure, I got her a dozen N-95 face masks, as there were already reports of a shortage of masks in Singapore. A dozen masks, I thought, would see her through for about a month, by which time this scare would have passed, like the SARS epidemic of 2003. That was certainly wishful thinking on my part. In fact, my first foreign visit to Israel at the end of February had to be cancelled because the Israeli Defence Minister had contracted Covid. As a result of these developments, we had already started passing certain advisories to the regional Commands to put in place precautionary measures as early as end-February. Worldwide, people had stopped shaking hands and were instead greeting each other with the traditional Namaste. Against this backdrop, we named the fight against Covid 'Operation Namaste'.[8] Right from the outset, the Army was at the forefront of the nation's battle against Covid, whether establishing quarantine camps or providing healthcare facilities. In fact, the first set of quarantine camps at Manesar and Chhawa were set up jointly by the Army and ITBP.

My primary concern, though, was 'Force Protection'. While establishing quarantine camps and looking after the needs of the general population was necessary, I could not allow my own Army to become 'unfit for war'. The first and foremost priority, therefore, was to ensure that units remained battleworthy. We had to continue manning our borders and carrying out our CI/CT tasks, irrespective of the circumstances. Moreover, I was apprehensive that should there be a breakdown in law and order leading to rioting or arson, it would fall upon the Army

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